



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Riverbend Academy
School Website: <https://riverbendacademy.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS: ACCREDITED MEMBER SCL: MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Riverbend Academy (Ormond Beach, FL) presents a robust CLASSICAL orientation across all six rubric categories, anchored in a Christ-centered, classical framework. Website materials and school communications emphasize a Trivium-based curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric), integration of a Biblical worldview, Great Books-oriented aims, and a community that views parents as partners. Documentation on the site also highlights teacher as mentors, a living curriculum, and strong parent partnership, all of which align with classical benchmarks. Evidence includes explicit references to a classical Christian philosophy of education, the Grammar-Logic-Rhetoric progression (K3–12), Progymnasmata memory work, and dual-enrollment pathways, as well as a mission centered on character formation in a Christlike context. The school also describes itself as partnership-oriented with families and a community that invites parent involvement. Taken together, these signals place Riverbend Academy squarely in the CLASSICAL category.

Key evidence anchors:

- Religious and metaphysical foundations: Biblical worldview, Christian formation, and Christ-centered mission (e.g., "Creating Christlike Character, Christlike Culture, Christlike Community.")
- Purpose and goal: Emphasis on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the true/good/beautiful; education as a holistic formation rather than mere information.
- Curriculum: Trivium (Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric) with K–12 progression; Bible-chronological history; core study areas; emphasis on Progymnasmata and memory work.
- Pedagogy: Socratic discussion in upper grades, explicit rhetoric training, and memory/recitation practices; contemplative/restful aspects alongside rigorous study.
- Faculty: Staff described as "Kind, Loving, Christian Teachers and Assistants"; concept of teachers as mentors and living curriculum.
- Parents & Community: Explicit partnership with families; opportunities for parent involvement and education; open-campus style engagement.

ABSTRACT

assessment: CLASSICAL

Note on needle-moving: Since the school already demonstrates a cohesive classical/Christian profile across categories, there are few large, obvious changes that would move the needle toward a more classical posture. If anything, further strengthening explicit Great Books engagement and broader rest/restful-learning language could fine-tune the alignment, but current signals already meet CLASSICAL criteria. What would move the needle section below provides optional, concrete steps for enhancement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school presents itself as classical Christian with a clear Biblical orientation and Christ-centered formation (e.g., “creating Christlike Character • Christlike Culture • Christlike Community” in its mission framing).
- Founding narrative emphasizes biblical Christian education and integration of theology with classical education, noting alignment with Recovering the Lost Tools of Learning and associations of classical Christian schooling.
- Public-facing materials describe teaching from a Biblical worldview and training students to view life through Scripture.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: theology, biblical worldview, Christ-centered, gospel, sacred/holy imagery (implied through the Christian framing), virtue in a spiritual sense.
- Negative keywords present: effectively none in school communications (no explicit secular-neutral or values-neutral signals observed in the publicly available materials).

Why this rating

- The materials consistently foreground a theistic/metaphysical frame (biblical, theological, liturgical cadence in communal life), with explicit Christian formation and a theology-infused curriculum. This aligns with the Positive Keywords cluster for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and runs counter to the Negative Keywords about secular, value-neutral approaches.

Citations: school mission and religious framing cited above. ool Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes formation, virtue, wisdom, and the true/good/beautiful as real and knowable, aligning with classical paideia aims; mission statements emphasize Christlike character and culture as core objectives.
- Messaging frames education as formation of the whole person (spiritual, moral, intellectual), not merely information or job preparation. The classical aim of mentorship, virtue, and human flourishing is evident in the materials.
- The school presents a long-view, “great conversation” and engagement with enduring questions through a classical Christian lens (e.g., Recovering the Lost Tools of Learning influences and classical conversation framing).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, true/good/beautiful, liberal education/paideia, great conversation, telos, human flourishing, moral imagination, spiritual depth.
- Negative keywords present: no explicit signals of “workforce/preparation” emphasis in public messaging; the materials resist secular, job-focused framing.

Why this rating

- The content consistently aligns with classical aims around formation and moral/intellectual excellence, with explicit references to virtue and the true/good/beautiful.

Citations: mission and purpose framing. turn0file5□

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence



- Core curriculum architecture follows the Trivium: Grammar (K–5), Logic (6–8), Rhetoric (9–12), with explicit mention of this structure in the academic pages.
- History is integrated across the curriculum and taught with a biblical/historical framework (history chronologically with the Bible). Great Books/primary texts emphasis appears in classical-Christian discussions and blog content about classical education in history.
- Explicit notes about Great Books/primary-text-oriented learning and the Great Conversation are reinforced in the site's classical-education discussions and blog entries.
- The site highlights specialized classical elements such as Progymnasmata, memorization/recitation, and memory-focused pedagogy (e.g., "Progymnasmata" and memory work in early grades).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, Great Conversation, memory work/recitation, history within biblical framework, formation through study of timeless texts, classical memory work, liturgical/narrative structure.
- Negative keywords present: none indicating a shift away from Great Books or classical canon; no heavy emphasis on social studies as a replacement for history, etc.

Why this rating

- The curriculum signals map cleanly onto Classical/Curriculum-Content expectations: Trivium-based structure, historic-literary engagement, and emphasis on memory and Great Books.

Citations: Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric, Progymnasmata, biblical-history integration, and Great Books orientation. turn0file5□ turn1file16□

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Upper grades show Socratic discussion and rhetorical training, including opportunities for debate, discussion of arguments, and rhetoric-focused work (Rhetoric track and guidance).
- The school uses formal rhetoric in high school and trains students in critical inquiry and argumentation, consistent with classical pedagogy.
- Lower-school practices include singing, chanting, and memory work (Progymnasmata, memorization in early grades), aligning with Scholé/restful and liturgical memory practices described in the classical framework.
- There are clear pathways for memory, recitation, and model-based learning (formation through imitation and practice) in the public-facing materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue/seminar, dialectic, great conversation, narration/recitation, chanting/memory work, restfulness/scholé, formation through imitation, rhetoric, and public-speaking opportunities.
- Negative keywords present: there are not evident signals of exclusive project-based, constructivist, or experience-based pedagogy dominating (the materials emphasize memory, recitation, and classical discussion more strongly).

Why this rating

- Pedagogy shows a clear classical bent: a mix of contemplative/restful elements alongside rigorous Socratic and rhetoric training with a strong memory and recitation component.

Citations: Socratic/dialectic and rhetoric emphasis; lower-grade memory/recitation; high-school rhetoric training. turn0file5□ turn1file6□

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Faculty profile emphasizes teachers who model virtue and are mentors; “Our Staff - Kind, Loving, Christian Teachers and Assistants” frames teachers as core relational figures in the school and part of the living curriculum.
- The school uses teacher-led mentorship as part of the classical model (living curriculum/portrait of teacher and student). The presence of a mission-oriented faculty culture is implied in the public materials.
- Faculty are described in terms of Christian character and educational philosophy consistent with classical education (as reflected in philosophy pages and staff pages).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, collegial/sympathetic faculty, virtue-centered teaching.
- Negative keywords present: no explicit signals of non-classical faculty models in public materials.

Why this rating

- The public materials describe teachers as virtuous role models and center the staff in the school's classical mission, aligning with the positive faculty signals in the classical rubric.

Citations: staff description and mission-oriented faculty signals.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes partnership with families and co-teaching relationships; materials explicitly describe parent involvement and education opportunities (e.g., “Learning and Partnership With Parents,” parent resources, and visitor-friendly campus).
- The mission/vision sections emphasize Christlike character and community, with houses and community structures designed to foster shared mission and family engagement.
- The school indicates openness to parent visits and involvement, and provides multiple channels for family engagement (blog posts, parent education, and shared expectations).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent formation, family involvement, home-school collaboration, open campus, parent education (book studies, gatherings).
- Negative keywords present: none indicating a purely consumer or minimal-parent-involvement model.

Why this rating

- Riverbend's public materials place parents squarely in the classical community-building frame as co-educators and partners, which matches the Positive keywords for Parents & Community.

Citations: parent partnership, family involvement, and open-campus signals.

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school sought to push toward a more explicit “Great Books” canonical program, the school could foreground regular, primary-text reading and discussion of foundational Western/Christian classics in more explicit terms across grades (Element 3). This would strengthen the Great Books/Great Conversation signals and broaden the cultural transmission aspect (Positive keywords alignment).
- Consider a clearer, publicly documented schedule of lay-catechesis or liturgical practices (even modest, classroom-level liturgical rhythms) to strengthen Element 1's liturgical/communal signals.

- Expand explicit documentation of a student-centered, Socratic seminar culture across more grade levels (Element 4) to emphasize a broader implementation of dialectic discussions and Harkness-style pedagogy beyond upper grades.

No major needle-moving changes are required given the current CLASSICAL posture; these suggestions are enhancements that would strengthen specific classical signals.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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